

Build quality

One of the most important things to look out for when pondering over a cabinet is its build quality. The materials that go into building a cabinet tells you whether it can handle the hardware that you put it. A full body made out of aluminium or steel is preferred over sheet metal because they aren't prone to dents as much and aluminium is a good heat conductor. Then come the locking mechanisms, the traditional screw-in panels are always preferred over the much more "accessible" cabinets since the only time you'll ever need to open your cabinet is when you clean it and when you are adding / removing components. Other things that are scrutinised are the quality of the plastic fittings. A strong frame implies that deformities caused by accidents like toppling over will not get the side panels jammed. The quality of the paint coat also is to be checked to see if the case will rust easily. Dust is your enemy since clogging up vital ventilation pores is what it does. Dust goes into your cooling fans and weighs it down and the build-up reduces air flow. Dust settles onto electrical contacts and with high moisture content it will short circuit your components. A mesh design with very fine holes or a removeable plastic mesh over a window are effective methods of reducing dust intake, however, regular cleaning is still recommended. The material of the cabinet is of great importance if you live by the sea since the saline air pretty much eats through iron and some steel.

Features

1. Multiple mounting locations for cooling fans

The pure number of combinations of component configurations that you can achieve while building a PC implies that there can never be a few fixed places that would cover all your cooling needs, you need to study the way air flows through the cabinet and figure out the fastest way to let cool air in and hot air out. Having more options to mount fans makes this possible. Also fans come in either 80mm, 120mm, or 140mm diameter, so a cabinet with mounting holes compatible with all three fan sizes is helpful.

2. Water cooling support

When going in for the extra chilling factor with water cooling, you need a cabinet which was designed for the purpose. Common elements in a water cooling system include a radiator, motors, component mounts, tubing and a reservoir. Majority of these components lie inside the cabinet, only the radiator which is from where the heat transfer takes place is placed either